to the hijaz’. We have seen how the Portuguese were opposed to both trade and the hajj in the Indian Ocean, which they further discouraged by the imposition of the onerous system of cartazes, the plundering of pilgrim ships, and the harassing of Muslim traders. A statement made during the 1567 Provincial Council under the archbishop of Goa, Gaspar de Leão Pereira, made these prejudices clear:

> Many Muslims and other infidels come to our ports with books of their sects and their false relics that they bring from the House of Mecca and other places they hold to be holy, and they pass through our territories with these things to their own areas. The officials of the customs houses are ordered that when these books and relics are seen, they should not be cleared but rather examine them and if they find them to be such, should burn them.

The Mughals did not operate in isolation in Hindustan, but kept themselves well informed about happenings in the rest of the world. Akbar was particularly interested in all major military battles and conquests beyond the frontiers of his kingdom and a European at court once overheard Akbar and his men analysing the Battle of the Three Kings, or the Battle of Alcazar al Kabir, in which the invading Portuguese forces of King Sebastian were defeated by the Moroccan Sultan of Morocco, Abd al-Malik. This was not an exercise in simple curiosity, but a way to keep informed about military technology and tactics, which the Mughals were supremely effective at adopting and adapting.

The arrival of gunpowder technology had profoundly altered Mughal battle tactics. The earlier Central Asian battle array, or yasal, was based on a centre and rear, which served as shock troops that drew in the enemy troops, accompanied by right and left flanks of mounted warriors who then encircled the enemy, galloping at high speeds, all the while firing at the trapped soldiers. Babur had already adopted the ‘camp battle’ technique of the Ottomans which involved the use of trenches and mobile wagon forts lashed together to protect the centre. Babur was able to combine two apparently contradictory elements—a highly mobile Central Asian cavalry with a more static entrenchment and artillery element and this ‘mobile fortress combined with a swarm of swift and dangerous horsemen presented a unique problem for the defending force’.